

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 9-10

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 9

Nita and the Ghost Walkers

“HERE THEY ARE!” said Gabe. He plopped the blankets in front of my father. We still sat by the morning fire.

“*Yakoke*,” said my mother. (*Yakoke* means “thank you” in Choctaw.) She unrolled the blankets and wrapped one around me.

“Here’s one for you, too, Luke,” she said, handing one to my brother. “And one for your father, and one for me!”

We sat looking at each other. My blanket itched, but I didn’t care. I was with my family and we were warm. For the first time since our home burned, we were warm.

As we started the day's walk, the sun shone and the sky was clear and cloudless. The road was frozen and my feet were cold, but the sun felt good on my face.

We walked through a thick forest and melting icicles fell all around us. A tree branch broke and fell to the ground. Nita squealed and jumped under my blanket!

"Can I walk with you?" she asked. Her tiny voice was so soft and muffled by the thick blanket.

"Yes, little Nita, you can walk with me," I said, giving her a big smile.

"I never had a big brother," she said. "Will you be my big brother?"

"Of course," I said. "I'd be happy to be your big brother."

That night at the campfire Nita suddenly stood. She walked close to the fire and turned to look at us.

“What are you doing?” her mother asked.

“I have something to say . . . to everybody,” Nita said.

“What is it?” her mother asked.

“I have a big brother. Isaac is my new big brother.”

I hung my head and hoped nobody would make fun of me. I thought this big-brother-thing would be a secret. I didn't look at Luke. If anybody laughed at me, it would be him.

I was wrong.

“Isaac will be a good big brother for you, Nita,” Luke said. “I like being his big brother. He will like being yours.”

I looked up. Luke was smiling at me.

"Yakoke," I said softly.

I looked around the circle. Everyone was staring at me, waiting for me to do something. This was a special time, but I didn't know what to do. I finally stood and walked over by Nita.

"I am proud to be your big brother, Nita," I said. "I will take care of you." Everyone nodded and smiled, and Ruth started singing the Choctaw friendship song. We all joined in, and for the first time our two families felt like one.

I hoped I could keep my promise, my promise to take care of Nita. Later that night, just before I fell asleep, I had a funny thought.

If I am a ghost, how can I take care of Nita? I asked myself.

By morning, I knew what to do. I could take care of Nita, as best I could, while I was still alive. I ate my breakfast in a hurry, and while everyone else was eating, I found a sharp stone. I cut two small pieces from my blanket.

“Nita, let me see your feet,” I said. Nita lay back on her mother’s lap and lifted her feet high. I tied the blanket pieces on her feet.

“Now,” I said, “your feet will be warm when you walk. No more walking on icy roads, not for *my* little sister!”

I was glad Nita now had warm blanket shoes. That afternoon the wind blew hard and the sky was covered with mean, icy clouds.

“We should find a tree to sleep under tonight,” Gabe said. “I think bad weather is coming.”

We built our campfire under an old oak tree with thick branches.

Gabe was right. The next morning a hard rain fell. A clap of thunder woke me up, but my blanket was already soaking wet. I stood under the tree and shivered. I tried shaking the water from my blanket.

A soldier rode his horse into our camp.

"No time to build a fire," he said. "Breakfast will have to wait. We need to move. Start walking. If the rain stops, you can build the cooking fires."

"Careful!" my father shouted. "The roads will be slippery!"

I could barely hear his voice above the pounding rain. Soon the rain turned to ice. By late morning, the world was covered in ice. We walked without stopping all day, with nothing to eat.

An hour before sunset the sleet stopped. The woods were thick on both sides of the road. Long icicles hung from every tree branch. The soldier rode up and down the line of Choctaw walkers, shouting, "Let's make camp here!"

We found a small clearing in a clump of trees and started building our evening fire. By now we were like one big family. Gabe, Ruth, and Nita were more than friends. They were family. We shared the work and then we shared the food.

A soldier dropped off a bag of corn for our supper.

"Milk will be here, soon," he said. In a few minutes, another soldier brought a jug of milk.

"Thank you," Gabe said. "Where did you get the milk?"

"We bought it from a nearby farmer," said the soldier.

"I hope that farmer has a lot of cows," Gabe said, after the soldier left. "We need milk for a thousand Choctaws!"

We had Choctaw corn soup for supper that night. *Pashofa*, we call it. Soft corn in milk chowder. Yummm!

The next morning I remembered what Gabe had said: “a thousand Choctaws.”

As we started to walk, I felt the warm shiver. I was afraid to open my eyes. My two families surrounded me, and I didn’t want to see anybody die.

“I do not want to know,” I whispered to myself. Then I felt a warm hand on my cheek.

“It is me, Isaac.” It was Mister Jonah’s voice. I opened my eyes.

“I was scared,” I told him. “Sometimes I know too much.”

“I understand,” said Mister Jonah. “I want this to be easy for you.”

“How can dying be easy?” I asked.

“I cannot give you a good answer,” he said. “But there is something you should see. Go ahead, look all around.”

I pulled back my blanket and stretched my neck high. As far as I could see, Choctaws were beginning their walk for the day.

“I see this every day,” I said.

Mister Jonah laughed. “You are not looking close enough.”

I squinted my eyes. The shiver was so warm I felt as if I was sitting close to a fire. I saw the Choctaw walkers, like before. But now I saw hundreds more Choctaws. Choctaw ghost walkers.

“Where did these people come from?” I asked.

“They came from all over Choctaw country,” he said. “They died from the fires. They died from sickness and they died from hunger. But they will never leave.”

“They are like you?” I asked him.

“Yes, son. They are like me. We are here to help you. Our lives are over, but we can still help the living.”

“Can I ever call for your help?” I asked.

“Isaac, I will be there when you need me.” As soft and quiet as the moon rising, Missus Jonah appeared at his side.

“I am here for you, too,” she said.

“Now,” said Mister Jonah, “we should be going. Today will be hard for you. Know that we are here.” I closed my eyes and they were gone.

“Isaac!” my father shouted. “Catch up!”

This day was the coldest day of our walk, colder even than our days in the swamp. Freezing rain fell all day long, and I could not forget what Mister Jonah had said.

“Today will be hard for you.”

I wondered what he meant.

I soon had my answer.



Chapter 10

Bloody Footprints

WHEN WE STOPPED for our noon meal, everyone huddled close to the fire. Everyone but me. I wasn't hungry and I was so cold I couldn't stop shaking. I stood under a tree, away from the icy rain.

"You should warm yourself by the fire," my mother said.

I was too cold to move.

"It is dry here," I said.

"Lift your feet," my father said. "You should move. You will never get warm standing there."

I covered my head with my blanket and leaned against the tree. I was standing in a pool of ice. I looked up and the snow was so thick I could not see the tree limbs. Nothing but white falling snowflakes.

“Come on!” my father shouted. “Time to walk.”

I didn't move. *Maybe now is my time*, I thought. *Maybe that is what Mister Jonah was telling me. Maybe today I will become a ghost.*

I felt a tug on my hand.

“Come with us,” Nita said.

“You better walk with your mother,” I said. If I was about to be a ghost, I didn't want Nita to see.

I wiped the snow from my eyes. The camp was empty and everyone was gone. I took a step. I had been standing for an hour. My father had warned me.

“Lift your feet!” he had said.

I should have listened.

Mister Jonah had warned me, too.

“Today will be hard for you.”

I tried to walk, but my feet were frozen to the ground. I pulled and tugged, and when I finally lifted my right foot, the skin tore away.

“Owwww!” I hollered. Pain shot up my leg and hot tears filled my eyes. I rocked back and forth, but the pain wouldn’t go away.

“Come on, Isaac,” Luke called to me. “You are falling behind!”

I clenched my jaw and raised my left foot, as gently as I could. I had sunk so deep in the ice, the skin of that foot ripped away, too. I jumped from one

foot to the other. My feet were freezing cold and burning hot at the same time. I never knew pain could hurt this bad.

“Please make this be over,” I said out loud. I felt the warm shiver.

“If you are ready,” Mister Jonah said.

“You are welcome with us,” Old Man said.

“It is warm here,” Old Woman said.

I closed my eyes and wished everything to go away.

When I opened them, I saw everyone who had taken a blanket: Choctaw children, boys and girls, and men and women, too. They all stood before me, floating in a puffy white cloud. No one wore any blankets and their sores were gone. The sun shone on a beautiful blue sky. I knew I was seeing a ghost world.

“You will like it with us,” said a young man.

“No!” I shouted. “No! I am not ready!”

I shook my head and they were gone. One step at a time I started walking. The snow was thick and my feet stung with every step. I looked behind me.

I was leaving bloody footprints in the snow. Mounds of snow covered the road. The snow fell in soft white flakes, but now the snow behind me was dotted red. I walked ahead, but I could not stop myself from looking over my shoulder.

Ten steps, ten bloody footprints. A hundred steps, a hundred bloody footprints trailing after me. I wanted to run, to leave the footprints behind me.

I did run, but the footprints followed me. The faster I ran, the more footprints.

“Make them go away!” I shouted.

“It is time,” said Mister Jonah.

“No! I don’t want to go with you!” I shouted. My voice was hoarse from shouting.

Then another voice cut through the snow.

“Son!” It was my father’s voice.

The Choctaw ghosts vanished. Far ahead my father waited. I stumbled and fell and my father ran to meet me. He picked me up and held me close.

“Isaac,” he said, “take one last look behind you.”

I turned my head and saw my footprints in the snow.

“Son,” he said, “you cannot keep your eyes on the bloody footprints you have left behind you. You must keep your eyes on where you are going.”

I took a deep breath. I nodded. From that moment on, even though my feet burned, I refused to look behind me. I looked where I was going and forgot about the pain. I was stronger than the pain.

Three days later my feet healed. But the healing began when I heard my father say those words.

“You cannot keep your eyes on the bloody footprints you have left behind you. You must keep your eyes on where you are going.”